FARAH AKHTAR, PhD

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Google Scholar: scholar.google.com/citations?user=clqoToMAAAAJ

PROFILE

Researcher and higher education professional with a PhD in Economics and five peer-reviewed publications, including one Scopus-indexed journal article as corresponding author, four as first author, cited over 45 times. Specialises in survey-based quantitative research using structural equation modelling (PLS-SEM, CB-SEM) on digital transformation, ESG practice and firm performance in emerging markets. Taught management and communication courses across five undergraduate sections with student evaluations of 96–100%. Brings five years of academic administration, including end-to-end management of thesis and dissertation defences for three degree programmes. Peer reviewer for six Scopus and Web of Science indexed journals.

EDUCATION

Universiti Tunku Abdul Rahman (UTAR) Kampar, Malaysia
PhD, Economics 2023 – 2026

Dissertation: Unlocking Growth and Sustainability: The Impact of Digital Transformation and ESG on Financial Performance
Advisors: Prof. Dr. Abdelhak Senadjki and Dr. Vikniswari Vija Kumaran
Key finding: returns to digital transformation ran through intellectual capital and ESG practice, with government policy support moderating the digital transformation path.
Funded by the UTAR Research Scholarship Scheme (competitive, merit-based)

Shaheed Zulfikar Ali Bhutto Institute of Science and Technology (SZABIST) Karachi, Pakistan
MBA, Human Resource Management 2016 – 2018

CGPA 3.58, Merit; Chancellor's Honour Roll

Shaheed Zulfikar Ali Bhutto Institute of Science and Technology (SZABIST) Karachi, Pakistan
BBA (Hons), Human Resource Management 2012 – 2016

CGPA 3.48, First-Class Honours

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Digital transformation and firm performance; ESG, CSR and sustainability; intellectual capital; SME performance in emerging markets; financial inclusion; survey research methods and structural equation modelling.

TEACHING INTERESTS

Principles of Economics; Microeconomics; Macroeconomics; International Economics; Business Statistics; Research Methods; Principles of Management; Organisational Behaviour; Human Resource Management.

PUBLICATIONS

Bashir, M. J. K., Senadjki, A., Salah, W. A., Abuhelwa, M., & Akhtar, F. (2026). Decentralized solar energy utilisation: Evaluating behavioral drivers and environmental awareness in the economically challenged territories. International Journal of Energy and Water Resources, 10, 96. Springer. (Corresponding author)

Akhtar, F., Senadjki, A., & Vija Kumaran, V. (2025). Sustainability meets digital culture: The influence of ESG on financial performance in Malaysian manufacturing SMEs. Journal of Innovative Digital Transformation, 2(1), 90–108. Emerald.

Akhtar, F., Senadjki, A., & Vija Kumaran, V. (2025). Mapping the underlying factors of firms' economic performance: Antecedents of digital transformation and ESG reporting. Malaysian Journal of Social Sciences and Humanities, 10(10), e003642.

Akhtar, F., Senadjki, A., & Kumaran, V. V. (2025). Navigating the digital era: Role of intellectual capital in enhancing the financial performance. Proceedings of BAFE 2024, Advances in Economics, Business and Management Research (pp. 21–61). Atlantis Press. Best Paper Award.

Akhtar, F., Senadjki, A., & Kumaran, V. V. (2023). Unearthing the nexus between ESG and financial performance: Does company size and age matter? Proceedings of BAFE 2023. Atlantis Press.

Under review and in revision

- A dissertation-derived paper on intellectual capital, ESG practice and government support (First and corresponding author).
- A cross-country study of CSR and institutional economic reputation among SMEs in Malaysia and Pakistan (First and corresponding author).
- Beyond economics: How institutions, innovation, and infrastructure shape entrepreneurship in emerging Asian economies. Sage Open (Scopus Q2; Web of Science SSCI) (Co-author). Revised and resubmitted after peer review (R1, September 2026).
- Present bias, impulsivity and debt literacy in "Buy Now, Pay Later" (BNPL) default risk: Evidence from young consumers in Malaysia. DECISION (Springer; Web of Science ESCI) (Co-author). Under peer review (October 2026).

Google Scholar citations: 45+. Scopus: one indexed article as corresponding author (Scopus ID: 60717294000).

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Universiti Tunku Abdul Rahman (UTAR) Kampar, Malaysia
Researcher, Department of Economics Jan 2024 – Aug 2026
Teh Hong Piow Faculty of Business and Finance

- Designed and validated a survey instrument and managed primary data collection from manufacturing SMEs across several Malaysian states; analysed data in SmartPLS 4 with Gaussian copula endogeneity tests, PLSpredict and importance-performance map analysis.
- Produced five peer-reviewed outputs (four as first author, one as corresponding author) with Emerald, Springer and Atlantis Press.
- Coordinated an international co-author team (Malaysia and Palestine) on a Scopus-indexed study of decentralised solar energy adoption.
- Supported faculty research projects through data collection, statistical analysis and manuscript preparation.
- Designed posters for research events and activities in Canva.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

SZABIST, Larkana Campus Larkana, Pakistan
Visiting Faculty, BSCS and BBA Programmes Feb 2021 – Jun 2021

- Taught Management Principles to BSCS (student evaluation 100%) and BBA (98.48%) undergraduates.

Visiting Faculty, Computer Science Department Oct 2020 – Feb 2021

- Taught Management Principles to BSCS undergraduates (student evaluation 99.45%), adapting business content for non-business students through applied cases and group work.

Visiting Faculty, Management Sciences Department Feb 2019 – Jun 2019

- Taught Personal Management and Communication to BBA students (student evaluation 96.49%; Spring 2018 section 97.71%).
- Designed assessments, marked coursework and gave individual feedback; taught entirely in English.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

- 12th International Conference on Business, Accounting, Finance and Economics (BAFE 2024), UTAR, Oct 2024. Best Paper Award.
- UTAR-UMSIDA Forum, Sustainability in the Digital Economy, UTAR, Aug 2024.
- 11th International Conference on Business, Accounting, Finance and Economics (BAFE 2023), UTAR, Oct 2023.

HONORS AND AWARDS

Best Paper Award, BAFE 2024 International Conference, UTAR 2024
UTAR Research Scholarship Scheme (doctoral scholarship) 2023 – 2026
Chancellor's Honour Roll, MBA, SZABIST 2018
First-Class Honours, BBA, SZABIST 2016
Second Position, Essay Writing Competition, SZABIST 2014
Certificates of Appreciation (4), SZABIST: NRCoBM and IRCoBMCT conferences and two convocations 2019 – 2022

ACADEMIC ADMINISTRATION

SZABIST, Larkana Campus Larkana, Pakistan
Academics and Records Officer Aug 2017 – Apr 2022

- Ran academic scheduling, examinations and course registration across three degree programmes (BBA, MBA, BSCS), and supervised the operational support staff.
- Managed the thesis and dissertation defence process end to end, from manuscript dispatch to evaluator sign-off.
- Ran campus-wide teacher evaluations each semester and reported results to the Head of Campus.
- Maintained student records in the ZABDESK ERP system and audit-ready documentation for Higher Education Commission requirements.
- Supported admissions through outreach to prospective students and invigilation of admission tests and examinations.

INDUSTRY EXPERIENCE

Summit Bank Limited Pakistan
Personal Banking Officer, Sales and Liabilities Apr 2016 – Aug 2017

- Managed account opening and closing for retail customers in line with bank policy, and built client relationships that supported branch customer-base growth.

SERVICE

- **Peer review:** eight reviews for six Scopus and Web of Science indexed journals: Humanities and Social Sciences Communications; Discover Sustainability (3); Future Business Journal; SN Business & Economics; Pertanika Journal of Tropical Agricultural Science; Journal of Tropical Resources and Sustainable Science.
- **Conference:** BAFE International Conference, UTAR: Publicity and Promotion Team (2024, 2025); Proceedings Support Committee (2024); Proceedings Editor, Master of Ceremonies and Publicity and Promotion Team member (2026).
- **University:** Postgraduate Representative, UTAR Students' Representative Council (2024/2025); master of ceremonies for university events, including the UTAR R&D Colloquium (2025), a Department of Economics webinar (2026), a Department of Business and Public Administration talk (2026) and a UTAR virtual study tour (2023).
- **Events:** organising committee, 13th, 14th, 15th and 16th Annual Convocations (2019, 2020, 2021, 2022), including the Graduation Dinner of the 15th Annual Convocation (2021), and the 1st National Research Conference on Business and Management (NRCoBM 2019), SZABIST Larkana; contributed to the 1st International Research Conference on Business Management and Computer Technology (IRCoBMCT 2020), SZABIST Larkana; Faculty of Business and Finance event 'Exploring the Bridge Between Research and Industry', UTAR (2024).

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

- CB-SEM using SmartPLS 4, Prof. James Gaskin (2024); STATA 17 and EViews training.
- Taylor & Francis: Excellence in Peer Review (2024); Choosing Quality Journals (2024); Publishing Ethics 101 (2025); Avoiding Predatory Publishing (2025).
- Elsevier: Scopus Platform Training (2024). Emerald: How to Select a Journal and Publish Effectively (2025). Wiley: Open Access Publishing Success (2025). Research Writing Workshop, UTAR (2023).
- **Conferences and colloquia:** UTAR Faculty of Business and Finance Postgraduate Colloquium (2024, 2025); ACS Publications: Strengthening Your Scholarly Communication (2025).

SKILLS AND LANGUAGES

- **Quantitative:** SmartPLS 4, AMOS 28, SPSS 29, R (lavaan, semTools), Excel (advanced), SQL, Power BI, Tableau.
- **Qualitative and research tools:** NVivo 14, ATLAS.ti, EndNote, Mendeley, LaTeX, Scopus, Web of Science, Canva.
- **Languages:** English (professional), Urdu, Sindhi (native), Punjabi, Hindi.

REFERENCES

- **Prof. Dr. Abdelhak Senadjki,** Professor and Deputy Dean (R&D and Postgraduate Programmes), Universiti Tunku Abdul Rahman, Malaysia. abdelhak@utar.edu.my
- **Dr. Vikniswari Vija Kumaran,** Senior Lecturer in Economics, Universiti Sains Malaysia. vikniswarivk@usm.my
- **Dr. Obed Rashdi Syed,** Senior Lecturer, Azman Hashim International Business School, Universiti Teknologi Malaysia. rashdisyed@utm.my